

REACH NEW HEIGHTS WITH  
DESIGN CO'S SUMMER PROGRAM

# UP-GRADE

Apply by 6/5 @ 11:59 PM  
[bit.ly/up-grade2026-apply](https://bit.ly/up-grade2026-apply)

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# 01 OVERVIEW

## What is UP-Grade?

UP-Grade is a 10-week, virtual, mentor-driven program where student teams partner with nonprofit organizations to create tangible solutions that advance their mission. Guided by an industry mentor, students collaborate across design, development, and strategy to deliver a working prototype while navigating real-world constraints.

## Who is eligible to participate?

All current UCSD students and recent graduates from all majors and experience levels are encouraged to apply! Mentors will provide support throughout the program, ensuring you have the tools and guidance to succeed.

## What's the time commitment?

We're looking for people with passion and dedication! We estimate a weekly time commitment of 10-15 hours. Each week, participants are expected to meet with their project teams and mentor, participate in program-wide workshops, and work on their project.

## Do I need prior design experience?

No! We welcome participants of all experience levels — whether you're a seasoned design pro or just starting your creative career.

## How do I apply?

Apply at [bit.ly/up-grade2026-apply](https://bit.ly/up-grade2026-apply). Applications are due Friday, June 5th at 11:59 PM PT. If you're a good fit for one or more of the roles, our team will reach out to you via email to set up an interview. Interviews will take place the week of 6/14 over Zoom. Offers will be sent out shortly after. An informational session about UP-Grade will be held on 5/27 at 6:30 PM in DIB 208.



# 02 TIMELINE

JUN 29 - SEP 4  
10 WEEKS

**Week 1** Kickoff &  
Challenge Introduced

**Week 2** Research & Early Ideation

**Week 3** Present Wireframes  
for Feedback

**Week 4** Visual Design

**Week 5** Interactive Prototyping

**Week 6** Finalize Designs &  
Start Development

**Week 7** Translate  
Designs into Code

**Week 8** Continue Building

**Week 9** Team Integration  
& Testing

**Week 10** Present Final Project

# 03 EXPECTATIONS

## Meetings

Students are required to have weekly meetings, reviewing their team's weekly process and any potential challenges.

## Workshops

Weekly workshops will be hosted by Mentors, DCo members, and UCSD alumni on topics related to their personal interests. Students are required to attend 6 or more workshops to keep their eligibility with UP-Grade.

## Participation

Attendance will be tracked to ensure team engagement and participation.

Students are allowed up to 4 unexcused absences for their weekly meetings and workshops before their eligibility is at stake. Warning will be given at 3 unexcused absences.

# 04 TEAM ROLES



## Project Manager

The Project Manager will oversee the entirety of the project from ideation to deployment. You'll be given a statement of work that closely outlines the weekly expectations and progress, ensuring that the project yields valuable results and will return a clear deliverable during the 10-week program. As a project manager, you'll coordinate team meetings, track deliverables, and facilitate communication between the team and nonprofit partner.



## Visual Designer

The Visual Designer is responsible for creating digital graphics that tell a story. This includes creating visual assets ranging from logos and icons to illustrations and other branded materials that closely align with the nonprofit's identity.



## UI/UX Designer

The UI/UX Designer lays out the structure of the website, creating the Figma file and focusing on both the user interface and experience. You'll be in charge of understanding the nonprofit's needs and translating that into an interactive interface, applying user needs and research insights into wire framing, prototypes, and high-fidelity designs.

# 04 TEAM ROLES



## Web Developer

The Web Developer brings the website to life, focusing on the technical aspects of the project and implements the designs through code. You'll be responsible for both front-end and back-end development, building the different components under technical constraints. You'll develop features, integrate systems, and transform the prototype into a functional website.



## Marketing Manager

The Marketing Manager is responsible for developing promotional strategies that align with the nonprofit's mission and audience. You'll oversee social media planning, create copy for various platforms, and ensure all marketing materials maintain consistent messaging and brand voice.



## UX Researcher

The UX Researcher shapes the product direction through structured research methods including interviews, surveys, and usability testing. You'll synthesize findings into actionable insights that guide design decisions throughout the project, anchoring product decisions in user needs.

# 05 NON-PROFITS



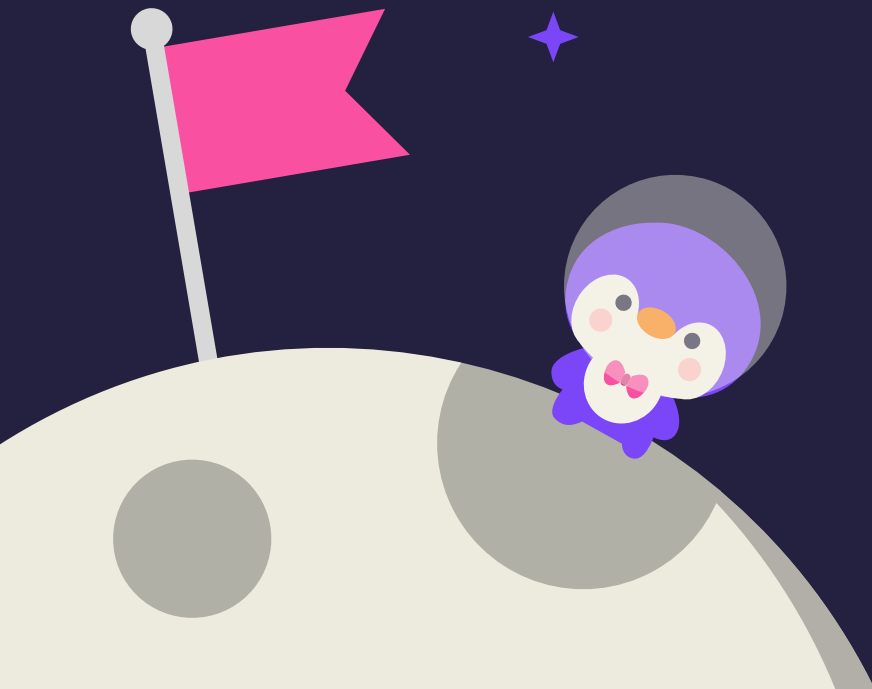
**Vietnamese  
Association  
Youth Alliance**



**Meals On  
Wheels**



**HandsOn  
San Diego**





# 06 MENTORS

**Wye Mun Chin**

UI/UX Designer, BD



**Rhea Acharya**

Product Designer, Brain Corps



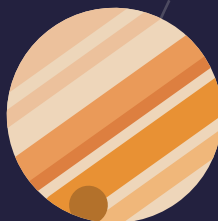
**Alan Tran**

UX Designer, Illumina



**Janelle Amores**

Product Designer



**Sirui Tao**

PhD Student, HCI



**Rina Takikawa**

Founding Designer, Radical Tempo



# 07 FAQ

## Where will the program take place?

UP-Grade 2026 will be fully remote, allowing participants to join synchronously online.

## What's in it for me?

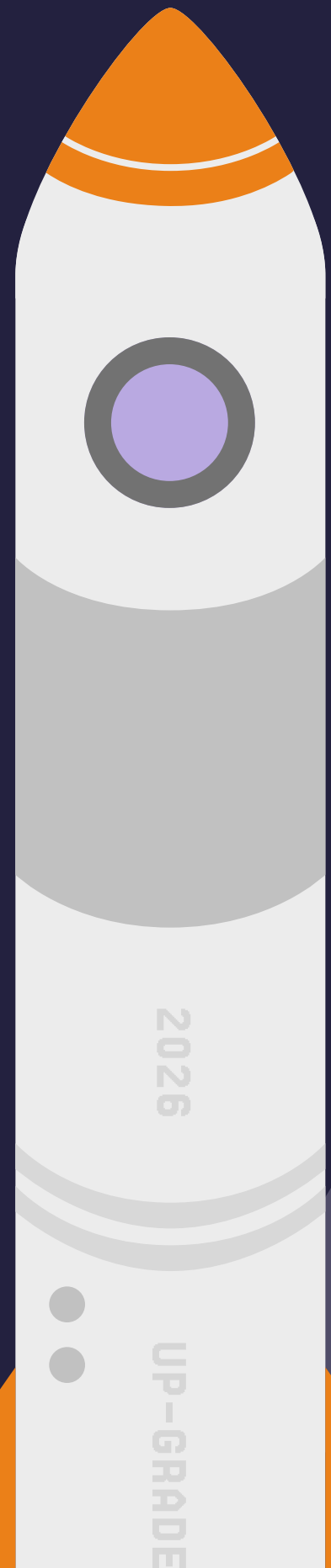
You'll deliver a case study for your portfolio, work directly with clients, gain access to mentorship from industry professionals, network with fellow creatives, and build real-world skills working on a cross-functional team—all in 10 weeks.

## How many people will be accepted?

UP-Grade 2026 will consist of 6 student teams with 5 participants on each team—30 participants total.

## What is the application process like?

Participants are selected through a holistic review process that consists of a written application and Zoom interview. We aim to give candidates a fair opportunity to showcase their unique strengths and potential.



# 08 TESTIMONIALS

## What advice would you give to students interested in UP-Grade?

For interested students, Shannon Chen, 2025 UP-Grade participant, recommends getting to know your team on a personal level in order to build new friendships. “Also, don’t do the bare minimum, put your all into the project. It’s important to learn from the experience and walk away with knowledge,” she advises.

## Did the experience prepare you for industry work/internships?

“The fast-pasted timeline and program structure definitely helped me get a feel for what an internship would be like. I treated UP-Grade like I would an internship, and because of that I now feel like I know more about what to expect and how to keep growing while doing industry work!” — Irene Joo, 2025 UP-Grade participant

## What skills/knowledge did you walk away with?

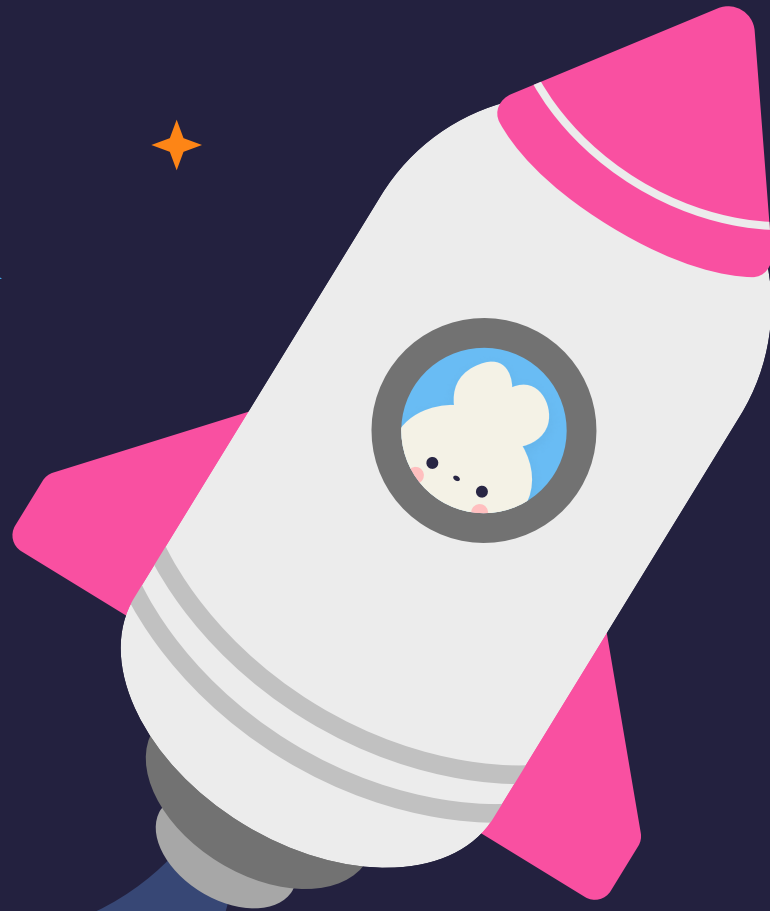
UP-Grade taught Shannon Chen, 2025 UP-Grade participant, accountability: with two weekly meetings and ten weeks, it was important to stay self-motivated. “Even missing one deadline could push the entire team back,” she said.

## If you had to describe the program in 3 words, what would they be?

“Collaborative, purposeful, growth.”  
— Irene Joo, a 2025 UP-Grade participant



# EXPAND YOUR HORIZONS WITH UP-GRADE!



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